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Grieve with Hope

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Grieve with Hope

Today's Reading: John 11:32-37

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"He said, 'Where have you laid him?' They said to him, 'Lord, come and see.' Jesus wept. So the Jews said, 'See how he loved him!'"

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When Jesus saw Mary and all the others weeping, he asked the question, "Where have you laid him?" He was then led to Lazarus's tomb.

And he wept. Many have noted that John 11:35 is the shortest verse in the Bible. It is. But that's not the reason it's especially noteworthy.

The fact that Jesus wept is important because it shows his followers how to handle grief.

He wept because of what death had done to his Father's once-perfect creation. He wept because of what death had done to his dear friend Lazarus. Death and destruction were never a part of the Father's original intent. They are evil intrusions into what was once perfect.

Please note Jesus' example of how to handle grief—especially when you lose a loved one. The apostle Paul wrote in 1 Thessalonians 4:13 that Christians should always grieve with hope. Grief is good. It's the Father's way of reminding you that there is much more after this life. Grief reminds you that eternity is your home and it is there that you will see your loved ones again. Only in heaven will all grief cease.

God wants you to grieve over your loss. It's human and natural. Someone once spelled grief L-O-S-S. As you go through life, you will begin to lose things and people you love. You will eventually leave everything in this world. And the more heartfelt the loss, the greater the grief is.

That's why tears are the Father's gift to you. They are his natural way to salve your soul. They cleanse the wounds in your heart. You need to grieve over your loss.

But don't stop there. Yes, grieve. But grieve with hope. One day, in eternity, you will be reunited with your loved one who trusted in Jesus. There is a better place awaiting you.

Jesus' followers grieve with hope. Those who don't believe in him can't grieve this way. Yes, you grieve—as all humans do with loss. But you grieve with an eternal hope. If your loved ones believed in him, you will see them again. Heaven is your home.

Jesus wept with grief when he experienced loss. He knew that tears are a gift from the Father to help salve raw emotions.

So should you. It's a gift to help your hurting heart.

But always remember to grieve with hope. It is hope that gives you the courage to face anything. And it is hope that reminds you that your grief is momentary in comparison to what awaits you in heaven.

For those who follow Jesus, death is merely an entrance into eternal life. It's not the end, but the beginning. Death has lost its sting.

It has no victory over those who believe in Jesus.

Jesus has won!

[from *"Hearing the Voice of God"* by Pastor David Chadwick, *Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC*]